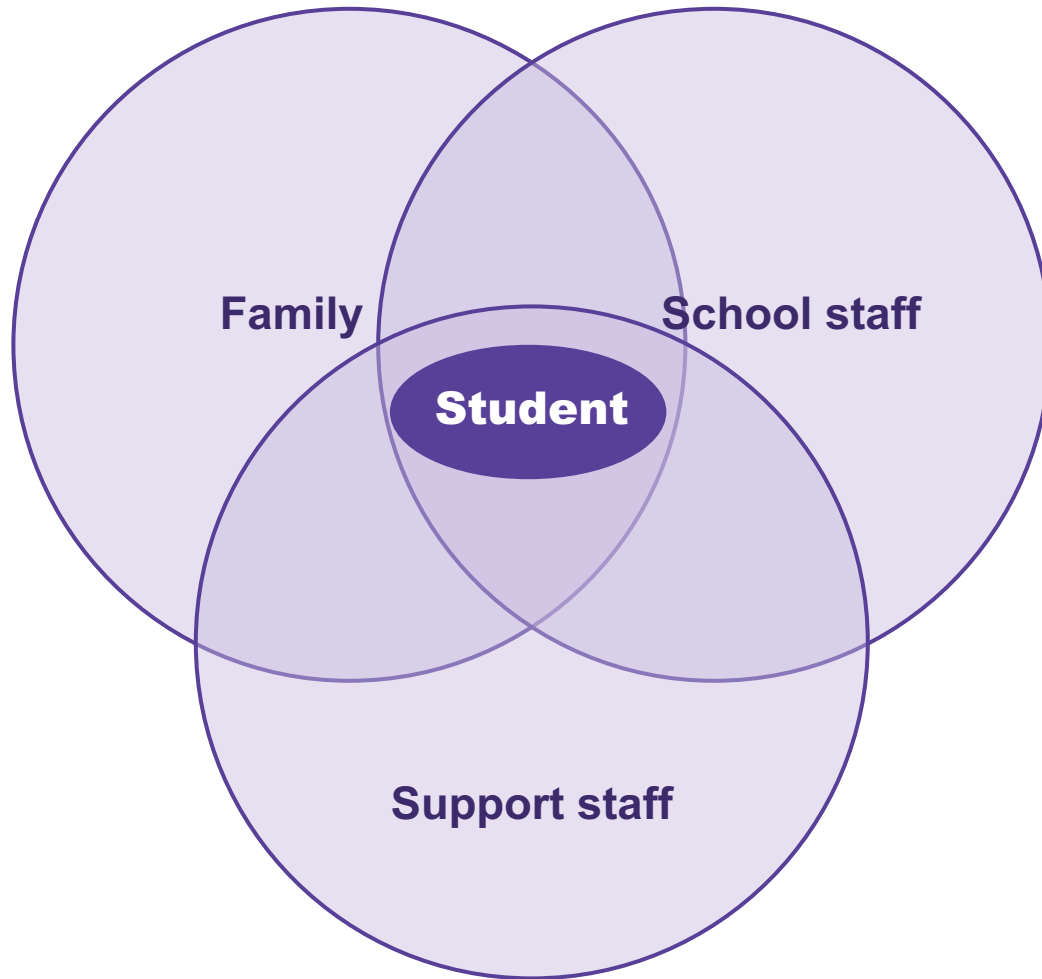




Education Support Staff · Session 5

Working in Partnership

Working in partnership



What is the goal of these intersecting partnerships?

Every partner brings different knowledge and a different relationship with the student.

The student is at the centre of every partnership.

Building a home-school partnership

Parents and families are the first and continuing educators of their children

Learning is lifelong and occurs in multiple settings

Partnerships, schools and school communities flourish when the diversity and strengths of families are valued and leveraged

Community engagement expands responsibility and resources

Partnerships grow from mutual trust, respect and responsibility

Partnerships need committed, collaborative and creative leadership

Family-School Partnerships Framework, Department of Education, 2020



What is effective collaboration?

Shared goals

Shared values

Mutual trust and respect

Consult on decision-making



Seeing other perspectives

Invite curiosity: How could we work together for better learning outcomes?

Centring student voice

Assume good intent

A communication rhythm with the teacher

Short, regular and planned works better than catching up when something goes wrong.

Regular

A few minutes at a set time, even once a week.

Brief and planned

What you saw, what helped, and one question.

The teacher's plan

Work from the teacher's plan for the lesson and the student.

No plan yet?

Ask: 'What should I know to support them well?' and agree a first step.

You help deliver adjustments. The teacher plans them with you.

When families tell you first

Families often trust support staff first. You see them at drop-off, pick-up or the bus bay, and you know the student.

Community roles

In First Nations communities especially, support staff are often a key link for families and teachers.

Know your pathway

Know how concerns are passed on, and what should never sit with you alone.

The warm handover

'That matters. Can we bring the teacher into this together?'

Keep the trust

Tell the family what will happen next, and follow up.

The trust families place in you is a strength. Your school's pathway helps you use it well.

Power dynamics

Power can sit in:

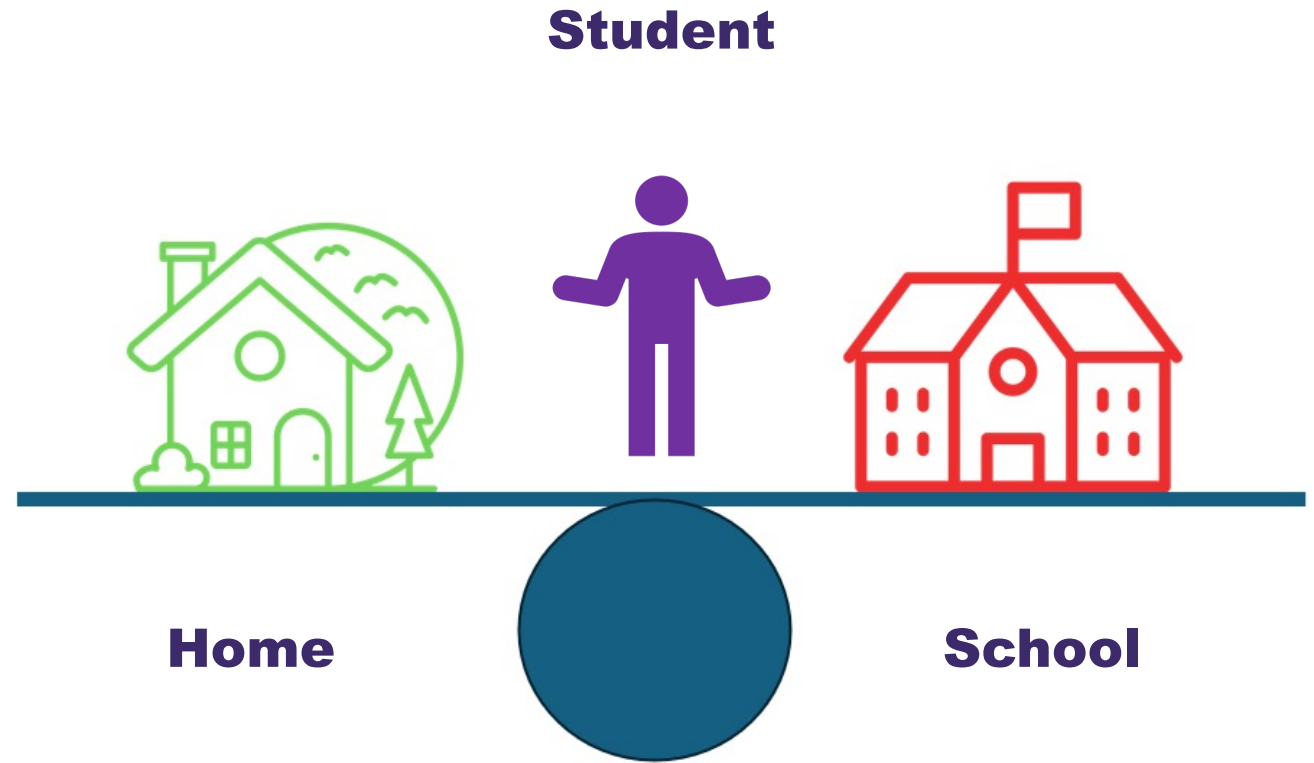
Socio-economic status

Historical / cultural experiences of education

Speaking English vs speaking a language other than English

Pedagogy / understanding of school systems and curriculum

Perception of the importance / experience of school



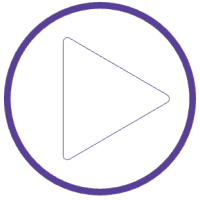
Power dynamics activity

On Post-it notes:

- 1 Write an example of an imbalance in power dynamics from a home perspective.
- 2 Write an example of an imbalance in power dynamics from a school perspective.
- 3 Write how you could address these imbalances.

Share at your table, or add your notes to the wall under Home, School and Solutions.

6 minutes



Student voice

What decisions were made, and who made them?

What impact did those decisions have on Adon?



Partnership activity

For each partner: what do they bring, and what challenges might they face?

Student	Parents and carers	Teachers	Support staff
Brings	Brings	Brings	Brings
Challenges	Challenges	Challenges	Challenges

8 minutes

Then compare: what do all four have in common?

What works?



Think of a family you have a good relationship with.

How did you establish this? What does it look like? Why does it work?

What works for everyone at the table:

Be prepared for meetings

Share information

Ask questions

Seek clarification

Assume the best

6 minutes



Meeting families where they are

Listen before solving.

Ask about communication preferences and priorities

Make room for questions and uncertainty

Explain roles, options and next steps plainly

Check what is workable for the family now

Avoid judging a family's pace, response or choices

Environment-first thinking applies to meetings too: what could the school change about the process?

Consultation literacy

Useful consultation includes:

A clear, shared purpose

Open questions

More than one way to contribute

Respect for student and family knowledge

Accurate recording of what was heard

An agreed action, responsibility and follow-up

Ask, listen, and follow up.

Consulting students and families

With students

Offer communication choices

Meeting preparation

Simple choices

Processing time

Sensory-friendly spaces

Behaviour as communication

Strengths and interests

Support - don't speak for

Clear, accessible questions

With families

Start with students' strengths and interests

Listen to families and value their insights

Use clear, simple language

Respect different perspectives / experiences

Focus on needs, goals and participation

Use real examples from school

Check for shared understanding

Agree on next steps

Keep communication open and ongoing

When student capacity runs out

Discuss capacity without blame. Home and school may observe different parts of the student's experience.

Meltdown

Shutdown

School Can't

Focus on safety, what preceded the situation, what supports recovery and what can change in the environment, task or response.

Partnership tools

Working Together Communication Tool

How are we going to communicate as a home school partnership? (Circle or highlight the ones that are most useful to you)	How often are we going to communicate this way and what are we going to communicate about?	Next steps and dates (write in any meetings or planned communication and when they will happen)
 Text		
 Email		
 App		
 Phone		
 Communication book		
 Face to face		
 Other		

Partnership Planning Template

- This template may help parents/carers and school staff to work together. You can tick a box or write down extra ideas.
- The first column lists what has worked well.
- The second column lists what has been challenging.
- The third column lists what could help.

What has worked for you?	What has been challenging?	What could help?
☐ Regular face-to-face catch-ups	☐ Ongoing written communication between home and school	☐ Having a regular time to meet
☐ Regular written feedback, i.e. communication book, reports.	☐ Sharing of goals and concerns	☐ Ongoing written communication between home and school
☐ Regular text messages	☐ Finding a time for parents and schools to speak	☐ Having an advocate or support person at the meetings
☐ Regular emails	☐ Understanding what is important to talk about	☐ Sharing how things are going at home or at school
☐ Regular video conferencing	☐ Feeling heard	☐ Sharing key things that may impact on home or school
☐ Recorded meetings, i.e. audio, video.	☐ Communication, i.e. expressing myself	☐ Voice of the young person being included
☐ Meetings with an advocate	☐ Listening for extended periods of time	☐ List of goals
☐ Group meetings with an advocate	☐ Environment, i.e. fluorescent lighting, noise levels	☐ Different meeting environment
☐ _____	☐ Negative experiences in the past	☐ Visual support for ideas shared in meetings
☐ _____	☐ _____	☐ _____
☐ _____	☐ _____	☐ _____

NCCD Meetings Tool Kit

The teacher and school use the Tool Kit to make the meeting purpose, consultation process, possible adjustments, evidence and next steps clear. Your observations and records of the support you give can be part of that evidence.

<https://www.nccd.edu.au/wider-support-materials/meetings-toolkit>



The screenshot shows the NCCD website interface. At the top, there's a dark header with 'Disability Standards for Education resources', 'Frequently asked questions', 'My bookmarks', 'Register', and 'Sign in'. Below this is a light blue navigation bar with the NCCD logo, 'An Australian Government Initiative', a search bar, and menu items: 'Understanding the NCCD', 'NCCD Phases', 'Resources and tools', 'Professional learning', and 'Help and support'. The main content area is titled 'Meetings toolkit' and includes a paragraph about federal law and a list of links under 'The toolkit'.

Disability Standards for Education resources | Frequently asked questions | My bookmarks | Register | Sign in

NCCD | An Australian Government Initiative

Understanding the NCCD | NCCD Phases | Resources and tools | Professional learning | Help and support

Resources and tools / Wider support materials / Meetings toolkit | Was this resource helpful to you? 203

Meetings toolkit

Federal law states that students with disability have the right to be consulted before the education provider makes adjustments to enable them to participate in education on the same basis as students without disability. Anyone in a personal or professional relationship with the student can ask for a meeting and everyone should know the purpose of the meeting and who will attend. Talking through the issues and using an agenda can assist people to make decisions about the student's needs.

The toolkit

This toolkit contains tips for people who have to organise or attend a meeting.

- > [Requesting a meeting](#)
- > [Managing meetings](#)
- > [Being prepared](#)
- > [Managing emotions](#)
- > [Keeping records](#)
- > [Was the meeting successful?](#)

Other practical supports

Autism Connect

National autism helpline



Emotional, practical and
financial support for carers.
Call 1800 422 737.

Bridge to the next family conversation



Prepare for one purposeful conversation.

- What needs to be understood?
- What question will open the conversation?
- How will the student's voice be included?
- What can be decided together?
- How and when will the school follow up?

Keep these notes for your conversation plan in Session 6.